

consequences. Douglass began sheltering runaway slaves, and his home became a “station” on the Underground Railroad, a system of safe houses and hidden routes for fugitives. During this time, Douglass questioned Garrison’s argument that the Constitution was a pro-slavery document. By 1851, the *North Star* (soon to merge with the *Liberty Party Paper*) was urging readers to fight through politics. Douglass’s Fourth of July speech in Rochester in 1852 attacked the hypocrisy of a nation half free, and called slavery “the great sin and shame of America.”

In 1859, John Brown asked Douglass to join the slave revolt he was planning in Virginia. Believing the plan would fail, Douglass declined. After Brown and his men were executed for the Harpers Ferry raid, letters implicating Douglass were found at a nearby farm. On learning this, Douglass escaped to Canada; he was not charged.

In the 1860 presidential election Douglass backed Abraham Lincoln, but was disheartened by the Republican Party’s attempts to appease the South. The new president promised to uphold the fugitive slave laws and not to interfere with slavery in the slave states. Then, in the spring of 1861, the first shots of the Civil War rang out at Fort Sumter.

Douglass had always hoped that a “liberating army” of Black men would march south and “raise the banner of emancipation.” In the wake of the Battle of Antietam, when U.S. armies forced a Confederate retreat, Lincoln issued the Emancipation Proclamation on New Year’s Day, 1863. This declared that all slaves in the Confederate states were free—the end of slavery was now the war’s objective.

Congress authorized Black enlistments in the Union Army, and Douglass helped with the recruitment, writing a call to arms for the Massachusetts 54th Regiment, the first Black unit. Overall, more than 180,000 Black Americans enlisted in the U.S. army and navy. In March, Douglass attended Lincoln’s second inaugural address. Yet prejudice was never far away; he was barred, along with others, from the reception in the White House. Douglass sent word of this to Lincoln, who ordered that he be admitted, then greeted him with, “Here comes my friend Douglass.”